The Blueprint for Certainty

Building a Data Governance Framework That Actually Works

Jon Garrow (he/him) · Lutheran Community Services NW

APRA NW · OCTOBER 6, 2026

Who’s talking

Jon Garrow · Lutheran Community Services NW

- Advancement Operations Leader at Lutheran Community Services NW
- Previous leadership positions in higher ed and academic medicine
- MS in Data Science, MA in Philanthropy Studies

WHY I CARE ABOUT THIS

Other people’s data decisions can have profound impacts on our data and our work. To work well across teams, we need shared definitions and processes.

Where are you today?

SHOW OF HANDS

Hands up if data governance is…

"SOMETHING OTHER PEOPLE DO"

"PART OF MY ACTUAL JOB"

"SOMETHING I'M SUPPOSED TO LEAD"

Where we’re going — 60 minutes

- 0–8 Why certainty: trust is the asset
- 8–18 What a governance framework actually is
- 18–32 Who builds it: Everyone, Stewards, Leaders
- 32–46 The **C·A·R·E** framework: consistency, accessibility, retention, ethics
- 46–55 Breaking ground: making it real without slowing fundraisers
- 55–60 Commitments & questions

EVERYONE STEWARDS LEADERS

One framework to remember: C·A·R·E

Governance boils down to four questions:

C — Consistency

Are we all speaking the same language — in our database and between systems?

R — Retention

Do we keep only what's relevant — and agree when to update or purge?

A — Access

Who sees what? Protect donor privacy **and** arm fundraisers to close.

E — Ethics

Would our constituents approve of how we hold and use their data?

Why certainty? Because trust is the asset

PART 1

Every dashboard, decision, and donor relationship is only as good as your certainty in the data underneath it.

Different mission, same need: trust

Millions of records

An international NGO, complex systems, a whole data team.

A focused donor pool

A local library foundation, one overworked database manager, a simple CRM.

[Different scale, identical need: **everyone has to be able to trust the data.**

It’s not just spreadsheets anymore

Today’s dashboards, API integrations, warehouses, lakes, and pipelines all rely on one thing: a strong, shared understanding of what our data **means**.

- A field that means two things breaks every report downstream of it
- An integration passing bad data scales the error, fast
- “I’ll just fix the spreadsheet” doesn’t survive contact with a pipeline

When it goes wrong, you may not notice it

STORY

Your background data failure

ANONYMOUS SHARE IN CHAT (2 MIN)

What rule, if it had existed, would have prevented it?

What a framework actually is

PART 2

Stripping away the frameworks until something useful is left.

A definition you can actually use

Data governance is the set of agreements about how we create, use, share, and protect data — and who decides when those agreements are unclear.

Shared rules, and **clear decision rights**.

Beyond “fixing spreadsheets”: a living ecosystem

Fixing a spreadsheet is a one-time act. A framework is a living ecosystem — one where data stays:

Clean

Accurate and consistent by default.

Compliant

Handled within the rules — legal **and** ethical — without anyone having to think hard.

Useful

The whole point. Clean and compliant only matter if people can actually **use** the data.

You’re already doing it — accidentally

Every shop has invisible governance:

- The unwritten rule about how to format a name
- The one person everyone asks before merging records
- The screening vendor — or the dashboard — you’ve all decided to trust

The choice isn’t governance or no governance. It’s accidental or intentional.

Who builds it: three roles

PART 3

We all have a role to play. Everyone participates. Stewards tend. Leaders decide.

Three roles, one system

EVERYONE

The Participant

Analysts, data scientists, fundraisers, the rest of us. Follow the agreements, flag what looks wrong, ask before improvising.

STEWARD

The Steward

Often the subject-matter expert. Owns a slice of the data — defines it, watches its quality, is the “ask-me” person.

LEADER

The Leader

Team leads and directors. Set priorities, resolve disputes, secure resources, give stewards air cover. Own the decision rights.

If you’re newer: your job is smaller than you fear

EVERYONE STEWARDS LEADERS

Three habits of a great participant

- **Follow the convention**, even when improvising is faster
- **Flag, don’t fix silently** — surface the weird record, don’t quietly patch it
- **Ask before you assume** what a field means

Monday action

Find out who is the steward for the data you touch most. If there isn’t one, you may have just found your next role.

If you’re a steward: you’re the translation layer

EVERYONE STEWARDS LEADERS

What stewardship really is

- **Define** the data — what does “qualified prospect” mean here?
- **Defend** its quality — monitor, clean, set the standard
- **Document** — so knowledge survives your vacation (and your departure)
- **Decide the small stuff**, escalate the big stuff

The steward’s superpower

You turn a leader’s policy (“data should be accurate”) into a rule a participant can follow (“ratings expire after 24 months”).

If you lead: your job is decisions and air cover

EVERYONE STEWARDS LEADERS

What leaders uniquely own

- **Decision rights** — who settles a disagreement
- **Priorities** — which data problems we fix first
- **Resources** — time and budget for unglamorous work
- **Air cover** — backing stewards when “no” is unpopular

The leadership trap

Avoiding clear decisions and difficult conversations in the name of false harmony. The cost: messy data, frustrated stewards, and a team that doesn’t trust its own dashboards.

Who decides at your shop?

RAISE A HAND IF IT'S YOU

When two people disagree about what a data field means or how it should be used — **who breaks the tie?** Raise a hand if you can name that person in under five seconds.

The C·A·R·E framework

PART 4

Consistency · Accessibility & Security · Retention & Minimization · Ethics

C · Consistency — data standards & input

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Are we all speaking the same language — inside our database **and** between systems?

- A shared **data dictionary**: what each field means and its valid values
- Naming, coding, and entry conventions everyone follows
- One agreed definition for the metrics leadership actually watches
- Enter it right the first time — **sloppy or stale input is a confident wrong answer**

A · Access — who sees what

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The fine balance: **protect donor privacy and arm fundraisers to close.** You hold some of the most sensitive information anywhere — net-worth assessments, internal due-diligence notes.

- Right-sized access — not everyone needs everything, especially the sensitive notes
- A clear path to **grant** and, crucially, to **revoke** when people change roles or leave
- Sensitive-note discipline: assume anything you type could be read aloud

R · Retention — the data lifecycle

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Data is an asset — but hoarding old, useless data is a liability. **Minimization:** keep only what's actively relevant and necessary to your fundraising goals.

- **Create:** where does it enter, and who's accountable?
- **Maintain:** how does it stay current — refresh cadence, re-screening?
- **Retire:** what gets archived or purged, and when? Agree the rules **before** you need them.

E · Ethics — would they approve?

EVERYONE STEWARDS LEADERS

Compliance is the floor; donor trust is the ceiling. Ethics is our agreement on:

- **What data we don’t want** — just because it’s findable doesn’t mean we record it
- **How we avoid bias** in the data and in anything we build on top of it
- **The donor test:** would this constituent approve of how we hold and use their data?
- **Do we all agree** on the ethical boundaries, and who decides when we don’t?

“Can” vs. “should”

ANONYMOUS SHARE IN CHAT (2 MIN)

Name one piece of information your shop **could** collect on people but maybe **shouldn’t**. Where’s your line — and who at your org gets to draw it?

Breaking ground — making it real

PART 5

Without the 40-page binder, and without slowing your fundraisers down.

Start embarrassingly small

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Failure is the 40-page policy nobody reads. The win is one rule, agreed and followed.

Pick one painful thing

The most painful symptom of your weakest domain. Just one.

Write one rule + one owner

One sentence everyone can follow, and one named person who owns it.

Governance grows by precedent, not by proclamation.

Protect the org without slowing the fundraisers

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Good policy is felt as **less** friction, not more. Design for the fundraiser's day:

- **Make the right way the easy way** — defaults, dropdowns, templates beat rules-on-paper
- **Bake rules into the tools**, so people comply without thinking about compliance
- **Say why, not just what** — "this protects the donor relationship" beats "because policy"

The data governance maturity ladder

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- **5 · Cultural** — people govern without being told; it’s “how we work”
- **4 · Governed** — clear decision rights, a council or forum, proactive review
- **3 · Routine** — definitions, a dictionary, a regular cleanup cadence
- **2 · Named** — someone is responsible; a few rules are written
- **1 · Accidental** — rules exist only in people’s heads

From “someday” to strategic advantage

The mature end state isn’t a thicker rulebook — it’s an organization that can **trust its own data** and move faster because of it.

Make it about the mission

Good data = more funding for the cause. That’s the why that sticks.

Celebrate the catch

Praise the person who flagged the problem. What you celebrate, you get more of.

Jargon you'll hear — a quick decoder

Governance has its own vocabulary. None of it is complicated:

Data steward

The person who owns a slice of data — defines it, guards its quality, the “ask-me” expert.

Artifact

A tangible governance output you can point to: a data dictionary, a policy, a decision log.

Rituals

The recurring habits that keep it alive: a monthly data-quality review, a standing definitions huddle.

Master Data Management

The practice of keeping a single source of truth for the most important data, and syncing it across systems.

PII

Personally Identifiable Information — anything that identifies a person (name, address, SSN). Handle with extra care.

Lineage

A data point’s paper trail: where it came from and how it flows — source → warehouse → dashboard.

Charter

The one-page founding doc: why governance exists, who decides, and what’s in scope.

Decision-right

The person who gets the final say when a rule is unclear or a dispute arises.

Your move

PART 6

One commitment, three altitudes.

One thing, by Monday

ENGAGE · COMMIT (WRITE IT DOWN)

EVERYONE — one habit you'll fix or question you'll ask.

STEWARDS — one rule you'll document.

LEADERS — one decision-right you'll name.

If you remember three things

1. **Governance = agreements + decision rights.** Not software, not the data police.
2. **Remember C·A·R·E** — Consistency, Access, Retention, Ethics. Four questions that keep data trustworthy and **useful**.
3. **Everyone, steward, leader.** Find your seat, take one small action, give the champion air cover.

The blueprint for certainty is simpler than it looks: C·A·R·E — and you can lay the first brick Monday.

Questions & war stories

Jon Garrow · Lutheran Community Services NW

jg@jongarrow.com · https://www.linkedin.com/in/jongarrow/ · jongarrow.com

Take this with you

Frameworks worth a look

- DAMA-DMBOK (data management body of knowledge)
- Apra’s body of knowledge & ethics statements
- Your sector’s privacy guidance (GDPR/CCPA + nonprofit norms)

Start-here checklist

- Name your decider
- Write your first dictionary entry
- Pick one rule, one owner
- Bake one rule into a tool, not a binder
- Celebrate the next person who flags a problem